C2 Writing

Summarising a text concisely

Reduce a long text to its essential argument in your own words, keeping the writer's stance without adding your own.

A good summary is short, accurate and neutral. It captures the main argument and the key support, uses your own words, and makes clear that the ideas belong to the original writer. This skill is central to academic and professional writing.

Step	What to do	Language
1. Identify the thesis	Find the writer's central claim	*The author argues / contends / maintains that...*
2. Select key points	Keep reasons; drop examples and detail	*This is attributed to... The writer cites...*
3. Paraphrase	Change structure and vocabulary, not meaning	*"Costs have soared" → expenses have risen sharply*
4. Combine	Join ideas with precise linkers	*While acknowledging..., the author concludes that...*
5. Check	Remove your own opinion; verify accuracy	*Use reporting verbs that reflect the writer's certainty.*

Choose the reporting verb carefully. *Suggests* is tentative, *argues* is neutral, *insists* and *dismisses* are strong. The verb itself tells the reader how confident or critical the writer is.

Common mistakes. Copying phrases from the original, including examples and statistics that are not essential, or adding *I think*. A summary reports; it does not evaluate.

Practice

Original: "Although electric cars are often presented as the solution to urban pollution, they still produce particles from tyres and brakes, and they do nothing to reduce congestion. Cities would gain more from investing in public transport and cycling."

1. What is the writer's central claim?
2. Paraphrase: "they do nothing to reduce congestion".
3. Choose the best reporting verb: The writer (suggests / insists / argues) that public transport is a better investment.
4. What is wrong with this summary: "I agree that electric cars are not the answer"?
5. Write a one-sentence summary.

Teacher page: answers

Print the pages before this one for students.

Answers

1. Public transport and cycling are a better answer to urban problems than electric cars.
2. they leave traffic levels unchanged
3. argues (the claim is made firmly but without extreme language)
4. It gives the summariser's opinion instead of reporting the writer's view.
5. The writer argues that, since electric cars still pollute and leave traffic levels unchanged, cities should invest in public transport and cycling instead.